

Alone in a Crowded Church

*Why Pastors Burn Out in Silence, and How Brotherhood
Brings Them Back*

JAMES BELL

Alone in a Crowded Church

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Unless otherwise noted, Scripture quotations are from the English Standard Version (ESV).

*Let him who cannot be alone beware of community. Let
him who is not in community beware of being alone.*

DIETRICH BONHOEFFER, LIFE TOGETHER

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INTRODUCTION

The Loneliest Job in the Church

HE IS IN A room full of people who love him, and he has never felt more alone.

This is the quiet condition of a great many pastors, and almost none of them will say it out loud. He preaches to a full room on Sunday. He sits with a dying woman on Tuesday. He knows the names of everyone's children and the shape of everyone's grief, and somewhere inside all of that knowing he has become a man who is known by no one. He carries the confessions of the whole congregation and has nowhere to bring his own. He holds the rope for everybody else. When he looks up to see who is holding his, the honest answer is usually no one.

I have been that man. I have stood at the door shaking hands after preaching on the sufficiency of Christ, driving home certain I was failing at the one thing I had just preached. I came to faith out of atheism, and I grew up without a father, so I learned early how to need no one, and I got good at it. The ministry did not heal that in me. For a long

time it paid me for it.

We have a name for this now, and it came from outside the church. In 2023 the Surgeon General of the United States put out a formal advisory on what he called an epidemic of loneliness, and he set its toll next to smoking. Robert Putnam had watched it coming twenty years earlier in the slow collapse of the ordinary places people used to belong, the leagues and lodges and unions and, yes, the churches. We built a society where a person can be endlessly connected and entirely unknown. Then we handed that society its loneliest possible job and called the job a calling.

This is not a book about self-care. It will not tell you to guard your day off and feel your feelings, though you should probably guard your day off. It is a book about a lie, and the lie is old. The lie is that the man God calls, He calls alone. That the anointing rests on one head. That strength means carrying the weight without ever once setting it down where another man can see it.

The future of the American church does not belong to stronger leaders. It belongs to deeper ones, and there has never been a deep disciple who was also a solitary one. I want to take the lonely pastor apart in these pages. Not the man. The lie. And then I want to show you what Scripture puts in his place, because it is older, and better, and far more demanding than the loneliness we mistook for faithfulness.

CHAPTER ONE

Surrounded and Alone

BEGIN WITH HOW STRANGE it is, because we have stopped noticing.

The pastor is around people all the time. His week is a wall of faces. Hospital rooms, counseling hours, staff meetings, the line at the back of the sanctuary, the dinner he could not say no to. By any measure a sociologist would use he is one of the most connected people in town. And by the measure that actually keeps a soul alive, the measure of being known, he can be one of the most isolated men any of those people will ever meet. The fullness of the week is part of how the emptiness hides.

The reason is not complicated. Nearly all of those relationships run one direction. He gives, and the people around him receive, gently and without meaning any harm. They bring him their marriages and their doubts and their dying parents. He cannot bring them his. The moment he does, the relationship changes, and some part of him always knew it would. A congregation needs a shepherd more than it needs a friend, and a man can spend thirty years meeting that need and slowly forget he was a sheep before he was ever

a shepherd.

Eugene Peterson spent much of his life trying to talk pastors out of the role the culture had written for them. He watched the American church quietly trade the pastor for a manager, the cure of souls for the running of a religious business, and he saw what it did to the men inside it. The job he described was not lonely because the men were cold. It was lonely because the role left no room for the man to be ministered to. He was the resource. A resource gets used. It does not get held.

Scripture has a scene for this, and it is one of the most honest portraits of a leader anywhere in the Bible. Elijah has just won. He has called down fire in front of the whole nation, faced hundreds of prophets alone and watched God answer, and by the next chapter he is sitting under a broom tree in the wilderness asking to die. What he says there is what every isolated leader eventually says. I, even I only, am left. The greatest prophet of his age, fresh off the greatest public victory of his life, undone not by failure but by the conviction that he is the last faithful man standing and that he is standing by himself.

Watch what God does not do. He does not rebuke the feeling, and He does not preach at it. He feeds him and lets him sleep. Then He corrects the lie buried inside the loneliness, because the loneliness was telling Elijah something false. You are not the last one. There are seven thousand who have not bent the knee. And the very next thing God does is hand him Elisha, a brother to pour his life into and eventually to hand his mantle. The cure for the prophet's isolation was not a better quiet time. It was another person, and a future that did not rest on him alone.

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not a better quiet time. It was another
person.*

I HAVE SAT UNDER that tree. So have most of the men I love in this work. We did not get there by sinning. We got there by believing something about leadership that sounded like faith and was really pride wearing faith's coat. That needing no one is a virtue. It is not a virtue. It is the wound we never let anyone near, and it has been killing pastors quietly for as long as we have asked one man to carry what God always meant a brotherhood to hold.

CHAPTER TWO

How We Built the Lonely Pastor

IT WAS NOT ALWAYS like this, and that matters, because the lonely pastor feels permanent. He feels like something the office has always asked a man to carry. He is actually a fairly recent American invention, and you can almost watch him get assembled if you know where to look.

For most of Christian history the work was shared, and not as a strategy. It was simply assumed. Paul and Barnabas appointed elders, the plural is right there in Acts, in every church they planted. Paul tells Titus to do the same in every town on Crete. Peter writes to the elders, plural again, in each scattered congregation. There is no church in the New Testament being run by one gifted man with a board that meets quarterly. The normal unit of leadership was a group of ordinary men who knew each other, and the weight sat on the group.

Something happened to that on the way to America. Part of it was the frontier. When the country was spreading faster than the church could plant settled congregations, the

Methodists sent circuit riders, single men on horseback covering enormous ground alone, and they were heroic and they were exhausted and a startling number of them died young. The model reached people. It also taught American Christianity to picture the minister as a solitary figure doing the impossible by sheer endurance.

Then it got tangled up with personality. The historian Nathan Hatch, in a book from 1989 I would put in the hands of every young pastor, traced how American religion in the early 1800s became democratic and entrepreneurial at the same time. The men who grew fastest were the ones who could draw a crowd on their own gifts. Charles Finney systematized it in the 1830s with what he frankly called new measures, and the revivalist himself became the engine. The meeting rose and fell on one man at the front. We have never quite gotten over it.

The twentieth century made it a profession. Seminary became a credential the way law school is a credential, and ministry took its place in a row of careers a serious man might choose. That brought real gifts, training and rigor and a body of knowledge. It also quietly moved the pastor out of the company of his people and into the company of an idea about himself, the idea that he was the credentialed expert, and the expert is by definition the one in the room who does not need help.

Late in the century the church met the language of management and fell in love. The church-growth movement gave us metrics and methods. Peter Drucker, the most famous management thinker of the age, took an interest in large churches and shaped the men who built them, and the senior pastor quietly became a chief executive with a vision

and an org chart and a brand. I am not mocking it. Some of those churches did enormous good and some of those men are faithful. But look at what the shape does to a soul. The higher he stands, the fewer people are left who can look him in the eye as an equal. By the time a man is on a stage in front of thousands, the number of people on earth who can tell him he is wrong has usually dropped to a handful, and the number who can tell him he is tired has dropped to zero.

I wanted that, by the way. This is not a chapter about other men. I came up reading the books and going to the conferences, and I wanted the platform and called the wanting a burden for the kingdom. It took me years to see that I had absorbed a picture of the great pastor that had almost nothing to do with the New Testament and almost everything to do with the country I grew up in. We built this man. We can say how. And what we built, we are not stuck with.

CHAPTER THREE

The Lie That Made It Holy

THE TROUBLE IS WE did not just build the lonely pastor. We gave him a theology, so that his isolation would feel like obedience instead of a problem.

The theology goes like this. God anoints a man. The anointing rests on him in particular, sets him apart, puts on him a weight the ordinary believer will never feel. To be that man is to be lonely, because he has been singled out, and the loneliness is part of the cost. We preach it from the prophets. We preach it most of all from Moses, the man on the mountain, the man who goes up alone into the cloud while everyone else waits below.

It is a moving picture. It is also close to the reverse of what the text says.

Read it slowly. In Exodus 18, before Sinai, Moses is doing exactly what the lonely pastor does. He is sitting as the single point of contact for the whole nation, judging every dispute himself from morning to evening, and his father-in-law Jethro watches it for one day and tells him the truth. What

you are doing is not good. You and these people will wear yourselves out. The work is too heavy for you. You cannot do it alone. That last line is not Jethro's opinion. The book sets it down as wisdom, and Moses obeys it, and shares the load with capable men over thousands and hundreds and fifties and tens.

Then it happens again, and this time God Himself is the one who says it. In Numbers 11 the weight has crushed Moses to where he asks God to kill him rather than carry the people one more mile. I am not able to carry all this people alone, he says, the burden is too heavy for me. And God does not answer the way our theology trained us to expect. He does not tell Moses to be stronger or to remember the anointing. He tells him to gather seventy elders, and He takes the same Spirit that was on Moses and puts it on all of them, so that, in His own words, they shall bear the burden of the people with you, and you shall not bear it yourself alone.

*The solitary leader under an
unbearable weight is not the picture of
faithfulness. It is the picture of a
problem God moves immediately to fix.*

SIT WITH THAT, BECAUSE it is the whole argument of this book in one sentence spoken by God in the wilderness. The solitary leader carrying an unbearable weight is not the picture of faithfulness. It is the picture of a problem God moves immediately to fix, and the way He fixes it is other people. The anointing does not isolate Moses. It gets shared

out, on purpose, by God, so the man will not die.

We took the one story that most clearly corrects the lonely leader and turned it into the story that excuses him. We kept Moses on the mountain and quietly lost the seventy elders at the bottom of it. I have done this in my own preaching. I have stood up and used the loneliness of the great man of God as if it were a badge, and never once mentioned that the God of that same man looked at his loneliness, called it too heavy, and refused to let it stand.

A theology is hard to leave when it makes your wound feel holy. That is why this one has lasted. It tells the tired pastor his exhaustion is proof of his calling, that the fact no one is carrying anything with him is the cost of being chosen. As lies go it is a kind one. It lets a man feel noble about the thing that is actually killing him. But it will not survive a slow reading of the books it claims to come from, and once you have seen the seventy elders you cannot unsee them.

CHAPTER FOUR

Two Are Better Than One

THERE IS A BOOK in the Bible that refuses to be sentimental about anything, and it happens to be the one that says the most useful thing in Scripture about trying to do life alone.

Ecclesiastes is written by a man who has tried everything and is in no mood to be lied to. He has had the money, the building projects, the wisdom, the wine, and he has come back from all of it with the same flat verdict, that most of what we chase turns out to be vapor. So when a man like that stops in the middle of his disillusionment to recommend something, you lean in, because he is plainly not selling you anything. What he stops to recommend is a friend.

Two are better than one, he says, because they have a good return for their labor. If either of them falls down, one can help the other up. But pity anyone who falls and has no one to help them up. If two lie down together, they will keep warm, but how can one keep warm alone. Though one may be overpowered, two can defend themselves. A cord of three strands is not quickly broken.

Read it as a pastor and it stops being a wedding reading.

Take the line about falling. He is not picturing a man who trips on a path. He means the falling a man does in private, the moral collapse, the slow giving-way no one sees coming because no one was standing close enough to see anything at all. Pity the man who falls and has no one to lift him. We have spent a generation watching good pastors fall and asking afterward how nobody knew. The answer is almost always the same, and it is not mysterious. Nobody knew because the man had built his whole life so that nobody could.

*Nobody knew because the man had
built his whole life so that nobody
could.*

THEN THERE IS THE cold. If two lie down together they keep warm. Anyone who has pastored through a hard stretch knows the chill he is naming. It is not weather. It is the low temperature of a soul gone too long without being warmed by anyone who is not also a project. A man can stand in front of a room that adores him on Sunday and drive home to a coldness the adoration somehow made worse, because applause is heat you cannot keep.

And the last line saves the passage from being merely practical. A cord of three strands is not quickly broken. The Preacher will not stop at two, because even a friendship of two can fray. The third strand is the Lord, and the picture is not a pastor and a buddy propping each other up by willpower. It is two men bound to each other and both bound

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to Christ, and that is a different kind of strong. I have needed that exact thing and gone years without it, telling myself the third strand was enough on its own, as if God had not spent the whole passage insisting that He usually does His holding through hands you can actually feel.

CHAPTER FIVE

Paul Never Traveled Alone

WE HAVE A PICTURE of the apostle Paul, and the picture is a lie of omission.

The picture is the iron man. The lone missionary who outworked everyone, took the beatings, wrote the letters, planted the churches, and did it on conviction and a spine of steel. It is not that the toughness is invented. The man was genuinely unbreakable in ways that should humble all of us. The lie is in what the picture leaves out, which is that he was almost never by himself, and that when he finally was, it nearly undid him.

Start at the beginning, right after the Damascus road, when the church was rightly terrified of the man who had been killing them. It is Barnabas who takes the risk on him. Barnabas who vouches for him to the apostles, who later goes and finds him in Tarsus and brings him to Antioch and gives him a place to work. Paul does not launch himself. A brother goes and gets him. And from there the pattern almost never breaks. Barnabas, then Silas, then Timothy, then Titus, then

Luke, then Priscilla and Aquila, then a long roll of names most of us skip in Romans 16 without realizing we are reading the support structure of the most fruitful ministry in church history.

Look at how the letters even begin. Paul and Sosthenes. Paul and Timothy. Paul and all the brothers with me. The man we imagine dictating alone in a tower is forever writing we, forever surrounded, forever naming the people in the room. He had a doctor traveling with him. He had churches he wept over and missed by name. The ministry that looks from a distance like one heroic figure was, up close, a man almost always in a company of brothers, and he wanted it that way.

Which is what makes the end of his life so heavy. In the last letter we have from him, Second Timothy, he is in a Roman cell, and the company has thinned to almost nothing. Read it slowly and it will break your idea of him. Demas, in love with this present world, has deserted me. Only Luke is with me. Get Mark and bring him, because he is useful to me. Do your best to come to me before winter. Bring the cloak I left at Troas, and the books.

That is the iron apostle. Cold, asking for his coat. Alone, asking for his friends. Facing death, and what he wants is not a larger platform or a final word for the ages. He wants Timothy to hurry, and Mark to come, and Luke is already there, and would somebody please bring the coat and the books before winter sets in.

*If the man who wrote half the New
Testament needed people that badly at
the end, the pastor telling himself he is
fine is not strong. He is hiding.*

IF THE MAN WHO wrote half the New Testament needed people that badly at the end, then the pastor standing at his mirror telling himself he is fine, that he has no time for friends, that he is called to a lonely road, is not showing strength. He is repeating the one mistake the apostle never made. Paul preached a gospel of being brought into a body, and he lived it. He let himself be carried. We have somehow decided that the men who carry everyone else are the one group exempt from being carried, and Paul, shivering in that cell with his short list of names, would not recognize the idea.

CHAPTER SIX

Leadership Was Always Plural

IF THE LONELY PASTOR is partly a lie we believed, he is also partly a structure we built. We took a job God designed for a team and gave it to one man, and then we wondered why the one man was always tired and always alone.

Go back to the plain furniture of the New Testament church. Paul and Barnabas appointed elders in every church. Paul left Titus in Crete to appoint elders in every town. Paul writes to the church at Philippi and addresses the overseers and deacons, both plural, in a single ordinary congregation. Peter writes to the elders among you and tells them to shepherd the flock, not as lords over it, but as examples. Everywhere you look, leadership is a group of men. Nowhere do you find the arrangement we treat as normal, one pastor at the top and a board beneath him that he manages or maneuvers or endures.

That word board is worth stopping on, because it reveals how far we have drifted. A board is a corporate idea. It implies a single executive and a body that oversees him, and

it sets the two in a low-grade adversarial posture from the start. The pastor learns to handle the board. The board learns to watch the pastor. Whatever else that is, it is not brotherhood, and it leaves the man at the center structurally alone even when the room is full. He is not among peers. He is across the table from them.

The biblical eldership is something else entirely. It is a group of men who share the actual weight, who can rebuke him and be rebuked by him, who know the church and know him, who carry the burden together so that no single one of them carries it alone. The pastor in that picture is not the CEO over the elders. He is one of the elders, first among them perhaps, gifted to teach perhaps, but a brother in the circle and not a man above it. The difference is not cosmetic. One arrangement has a built-in cure for loneliness. The other has a built-in cause of it.

*We took a job God designed for a team
and gave it to one man, then wondered
why the one man was always alone.*

I HAVE RUN A church as the man with a board, and I have served in a church as one elder among brothers, and I can tell you the second one nearly saved my life. When the weight is shared by design, you do not have to manufacture vulnerability as a special event. It is just Tuesday. The men already know the hard thing because they are already carrying it with you. That is not a program a church bolts on. It is the shape God drew, and we will keep producing lonely,

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breakable pastors as long as we keep ignoring it and calling the corporate version leadership.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The One Anothers Were Written for You Too

THERE ARE AROUND FIFTY commands in the New Testament built on the same two words. One another. Love one another. Bear one another's burdens. Confess your sins to one another. Encourage one another. Forgive one another. Carry, comfort, build up, pray for, be honest with, one another. They are the basic operating instructions for the Christian life, and the pastor preaches them constantly.

He just exempts himself.

Watch how it works in an ordinary church. Confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, James says, that you may be healed. The pastor preaches that text and means it, and he is the one man in the building who confesses to no one. He hears confessions all week. He makes none. Bear one another's burdens, Paul says, and so fulfill the law of Christ. The pastor carries the burdens of two hundred people and sets his own down nowhere. Encourage one another and build each other up. He is the chief encourager and almost no one is assigned to him.

None of this is decided on purpose. No pastor stands up and announces that the one anothers are for the congregation and not for the staff. It happens by drift, because the role rewards it. The man who always gives and never needs looks the most spiritual, the most sacrificial, the most like what we think a shepherd should be. So he gives and gives, and the giving hides the need, and the need does not go away because he is ignoring it. It just goes underground, where needs get dangerous.

*The pastor hears confessions all week.
He makes none.*

HERE IS THE THING the exemption misses. The one anothers were not given because Christians are weak and pastors are strong. They were given because this is how God designed every soul to be kept, including the soul of the man at the front. When Scripture says we are members of one another, it does not add a footnote excluding the ordained. The pastor is not the exception to the body. He is a member of it who has been quietly behaving as if he were the head, and there is already a Head, and the job is taken. The most pastoral thing a tired minister can do is stop preaching the one anothers at people and start, somewhere, with one trusted man, obeying them himself.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Why Pastors Hide

SO WHY DOES HE not just do it. If the loneliness is this dangerous and the cure is this clear, why does the average pastor go years, sometimes decades, without a single peer who knows the truth about him. The answer is not laziness. It is fear, and the fear is reasonable, which is exactly what makes it so hard to break.

Start with the performance, because the performance is not optional. The job genuinely requires a man to stand up week after week and project confidence in God, often more confidence than he feels that morning. That is not hypocrisy. A shepherd does not dump his every doubt on a frightened flock. But a skill practiced long enough becomes a reflex, and the reflex does not switch off when he steps down from the platform. The man who has learned to look steady in the pulpit when he is shaking inside has learned to look steady everywhere, including in the rooms where he most needs to fall apart.

Then there is the shame, and a pastor's shame has a particular weight. When an ordinary believer confesses a sin, he expects grace. When a pastor even imagines confessing

the same sin, he sees his career ending. The same struggle that would be forgivable in a member feels disqualifying in a minister, because his standing, his income, his housing, and his identity are all fused to the assumption that he is better than that. So the very sins that most need to be dragged into the light are the ones he has the most concrete reasons to keep buried. He is not hiding because he is worse than his people. He is hiding because he has more to lose by being known.

And the platform multiplies all of it. The bigger the ministry, the more catastrophic exposure feels, so the higher a man rises the more he has to hide and the fewer safe people remain to hide nothing from. It is a cruel arithmetic. Success in this profession tends to increase a man's isolation at the exact rate it increases his influence. The pastors most in need of a brother are often the ones who have made themselves least able to have one.

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I AM DESCRIBING MY own younger ministry as much as anyone's. I hid because I had built a self that could not afford to be seen, and the hiding worked, right up until it didn't. This is the part of the book where I want to be gentle, because shaming a man for hiding is like shouting at someone for limping. The hiding is a wound, not a character flaw. But it is also a trap, and traps do not spring open on their own.

Somebody has to decide that being known is worth more than being safe, and then take the first humiliating step toward it. The next chapters are about what that step actually looks like.

CHAPTER NINE

The Friendship a Pastor Actually Needs

WHEN A LONELY PASTOR finally goes looking for help, he is usually offered the wrong thing, because the church has a lot of substitutes for friendship and keeps handing them to him as if they were the real article.

He is offered a mentor. A mentor is a gift, but a mentor stands above you, and you do not show a man above you your worst. He is offered a coach, and a coach can be genuinely useful, but a coach is paid, and a relationship you pay for is one you can end the moment it costs you something true. He is offered a network, and a network is a room full of people exchanging value, which is a fine thing and a lonely one, because everybody in it is performing the very competence the pastor is exhausted from performing. He is offered, finally, his wife, and his wife should know him better than anyone on earth, but a man who makes his wife his only outlet has not found brotherhood. He has handed one person a weight God meant to be shared by several, and slowly turned his marriage into his support group.

None of those is the thing. The thing is a peer. Another man who does the same impossible work, who is unimpressed by your gifts because he has the same ones, who owes you nothing and wants nothing from you, who has seen the worst of you and is still answering the phone. Mutual, not hierarchical. Off the platform, where neither of you is performing. A friendship in which you are not the pastor. You are just a man, and he is just a man, and the relief of that is almost physical the first time you feel it.

*You need a man who has seen the worst
of you and is still answering the phone.*

THAT KIND OF FRIEND is rare, and I will not pretend otherwise. But rare is not the same as impossible, and most pastors have never actually looked, because looking requires admitting you need one, and admitting you need one is the very thing the lonely pastor has organized his whole life to avoid. The good news, and it is genuinely good news, is that there are far more lonely pastors than there are lonely men who have done something about it. The next pastor over is almost certainly carrying the same secret weight you are. He is also almost certainly waiting for someone else to go first. One of you has to. The whole rest of this book is an argument that it should be you.

CHAPTER TEN

What the Methodists Knew

HERE IS THE PART that should make us hopeful and a little embarrassed at the same time. The church already solved this. We invented the cure centuries ago, used it to enormous effect, and then mostly forgot we had it.

Look at the early Methodists. The thing that actually formed people in that movement was not the open-air preaching, as famous as it became. It was the small, unglamorous structures underneath it, the classes and the bands. A band was a handful of believers who met every week to answer a fixed set of brutally honest questions. What known sins have you committed since we last met. What temptations have you faced. How were you delivered. What have you thought, said, or done, of which you doubt whether it be sin or not. And then the one that undoes most of us. Is there anything you desire to keep secret. They asked each other that. On purpose. Every week. The genius was not the intensity, it was the structure. Honesty became a scheduled obligation instead of a heroic event, and ordinary people

were kept by it for life.

Two centuries later Dietrich Bonhoeffer, leading an underground seminary in Nazi Germany, wrote it down again in a short book called *Life Together*. He warned about what he called the pious fellowship, the Christian community that permits no one to be a sinner, where everyone has to pretend to be holy and therefore everyone is alone in the crowd, each one hiding the very thing that fellowship exists to heal. His cure was confession to a single brother. He argued that sin wants to stay hidden, that it gains its power in the dark, and that the act of saying it out loud to one ordinary fellow Christian breaks something the sin had been counting on. The breakthrough to community, he said, runs through the breakthrough to confession.

*Sin gains its power in the dark, and
saying it out loud to one ordinary
brother breaks something it had been
counting on.*

WE DO NOT HAVE to invent anything. We have the band questions. We have *Life Together*. We have two thousand years of believers who knew that a soul is kept in the company of a few honest others, not in the isolation we have mistaken for spiritual maturity. What we lack is not the method. What we lack is the willingness to be the pastor who admits he needs the same medicine he has been prescribing to everyone else. The Methodists were not stronger than us. They were just less ashamed of needing each other, and they

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built a structure that made the needing normal. We can do that again. It is not complicated. It is only humbling, which is harder.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

A Network for the Last Lonely Profession

I DID NOT START the Pastors Connection Network because I had a strategy. I started it because I had been the man in this book, and a few brothers reached into that and would not let me drown, and I could not stand the thought of how many men were still under the broom tree with no one reaching in.

I told you at the beginning that I came to faith out of atheism and grew up without a father. Put those two together and you get a particular kind of man, one who learned that the safest thing to do with a need is to deny he has it. I carried that straight into ministry, where it looked like strength and got rewarded like virtue, and it nearly cost me everything that mattered before anyone close enough to help even knew I was in trouble. What saved me was not a conference or a book or a better system. It was a small number of pastors who knew the work, knew my worst, and stayed. Brothers. The thing this whole book has been about.

So the Pastors Connection Network is not a brand, and it is not a content funnel, and it is not another platform asking for

your attention and your money. It is a deliberately simple answer to a deadly simple problem. Pastors are alone, and they were never meant to be, and almost no one is going to fix that for them unless someone builds the room where it can happen. PCN is that room. A structure for ordinary pastors to find a few real brothers, to ask each other the old honest questions, to carry the weight the way Moses carried it after the seventy, which is to say together.

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I WANT TO BE honest about its limits. A network cannot make you confess. It cannot make you answer the phone at midnight or admit the thing you have been hiding for nine years. It can only do what the band and the class did, which is make the needing normal and put the brothers within reach. The rest is on you, and on me. But that is most of the battle, because the hardest part of brotherhood is not the friendship itself. It is getting a proud, tired, hiding man to believe he is allowed to want one. If PCN does nothing but tell ten thousand pastors that they are allowed to want a brother, and then puts one within arm's reach, it will have undone a lie that has been breaking this profession for two hundred years.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Make the Call

YOU ALREADY HAVE A name.

I have watched this happen in enough rooms to know that you do. Somewhere in the last few chapters a face came to mind, a man you could call, a brother you lost touch with or never quite started with, someone who would understand the thing you cannot say to your congregation or your board. You felt the thought arrive and you felt yourself set it back down, because you are busy, because it would be awkward, because he is probably fine and you do not want to be the weak one who reached out.

Let me take the last excuse first, because it is the one that keeps the most pastors alone. He is not fine. Read this whole book back through his eyes. He is standing in the same crowded church, hiding the same weight, telling himself the same story about strength, waiting for someone else to go first so he does not have to be the one who admits he is drowning. You are both waiting for the other man to make the call. One of you has to break, and breaking first is not weakness, it is leadership, the only kind that was ever real. The strong man in the kingdom of God is not the one who

needs no one. It is the one who is secure enough to need someone out loud.

So do not build a program. Do not wait for a conference or a clean season or the version of yourself who finally has it together. That man is not coming, and the loneliness is not going to retire on its own. Pick up the phone. Call the name. Say the plain, humbling sentence, that you have been carrying this alone for too long and you do not want to anymore, and would he be willing to be a real friend, the kind who asks the hard questions and tells the truth. That is the whole revolution. Not a movement. A call.

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THE CHURCH DOES NOT need stronger lonely men. We have had two centuries of them, and we have buried too many of them young, watched too many of them fall, and asked too many times afterward how nobody knew. The future the gospel is actually building does not run through bigger platforms or harder, more solitary leaders. It runs through brothers. Through Aaron and Hur holding up the arms that could not hold themselves up. Through the seventy elders God refused to let Moses do without. Through Luke in the cold cell and the coat coming before winter. Through two ordinary men, bound to each other and both bound to Christ, a cord not quickly broken.

You are still holding the phone. The broom tree is behind you and the brother is one call away. Make it.